

Chapter 122-5

After sending the message to Xu Qingzhu, Liang Shi said to Chen Mian very seriously, "She's not my girlfriend."

Chen Mian's car had just stopped by the roadside. Only the dim yellow light remained inside the car. Liang Shi's voice was gentle, carrying a hint of tenderness, "I'm married."

Chen Mian paused slightly. Those cold eyes flickered for a moment, then she curved her lips into a smile, "Congratulations."

"I'll introduce you two someday." Liang Shi said, "She knows about you."

This surprised Chen Mian.

Liang Shi said, "She also knows about Qi Jiao."

At the mention of Qi Jiao, Chen Mian's attitude shifted, though her voice remained cold.

She said, "Then let's meet sometime."

After saying this, she tossed the car keys into her pocket, and her thin figure walked toward the bar.

This street was noisy and bustling, with signs flashing in all colors of light.

Chen Mian's figure mingled among the crowd. Those strange lights shone on her ink-blue hair, making her entire being seem lonely and desolate.

Out of place with this world.

Liang Shi stared at her back, thought for two seconds, then followed.

She suddenly had an intuition—Chen Mian was using this way to remember Qi Jiao.

Because Qi Jiao had died, but no one knew.

There was no one around her who could talk about Qi Jiao with her.

So Chen Mian would treat everyone who knew about Qi Jiao with tolerance.

Simply because they still remembered Qi Jiao, and could help her remember—that Qi Jiao had once existed.

//

It was only after Liang Shi walked into the bar that she received Xu Qingzhu's reply.

Xu Qingzhu's cool, clear voice came through the speaker, hard to hear clearly in the noisy environment.

Liang Shi turned the volume up to maximum, then held the phone to her ear, covering one ear with her hand.

That voice carried a hint of helplessness, "Send me the address. I'll come find you in a bit."

Liang Shi directly sent her the location.

Xu Qingzhu sent another voice message: "I'm not angry. You're just drinking."

Liang Shi: [.....]

Perhaps because of a guilty conscience, even after hearing Xu Qingzhu say this, Liang Shi still felt that Xu Qingzhu was angry.

Liang Shi thought for a moment: [How about I wait until you arrive before drinking?]

This time Xu Qingzhu was truly exasperated. Her words contained a hint of laughter: "Is that really necessary? If people heard, they'd say you're henpecked."¹

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi sent her a voice message in the noisy bar, lips close to the microphone.

Her voice was mixed with the noisy background, her gentle voice carrying a hint of proud stubbornness, "Henpecked it is then. It's not some serious disease."

After sending it, taking advantage of the fact that no one was paying attention to her, she sent another: "As long as you're not angry, who cares what others think."

Xu Qingzhu: [.....]

The heavy metal music in the bar was giving people headaches. Men and women on the dance floor were swaying their bodies.

This was a rather open bar. Quite a few people were carrying drinks to chat people up, kissing passionately right at the bar counter.

Everyone was used to it.

Though there weren't too many such people—most just handed over a business card, or directly linked arms and went to get a room next door.

Right next door was a large hotel.

Liang Shi had never been to a place like this. Seeing two people kissing inseparably at the bar counter, she said to Chen Mian in surprise, "This is too uninhibited. At least go to a hotel."

She didn't quite understand why Chen Mian would like coming to a place like this.

She had thought that a melancholic artist like Chen Mian would go to a quiet bar if she went to one at all—playing some artistic songs, everyone sitting there watching the bartender show off mixing techniques.

Liang Shi thought this way, and asked as much.

After two drinks, her body warmed up, and the fatigue finally began to dissipate somewhat.

The only thing the two of them had in common was Qi Jiao.

Because they were both reminiscing about Qi Jiao, they could sit here drinking together.

Chen Mian's sickly pale fingers held a glass of "Flaming Rose." The red liquid swayed gently in the transparent glass as her eyes looked through the glass at the lights, and at this world.

The liquor flowed past her lips and tongue, down her throat, swallowed into her stomach.

Chen Mian curved her lips in a slight smile, "Don't you think this is the best place to observe people?"

"Human nature is vile." Chen Mian's alcohol-soaked voice grew even colder. "They're cold, selfish—this is the place where they release themselves."

Chen Mian looked at the women kissing in the distance. "Don't you think that being able to go into heat anytime, anywhere, able to couple without any love—they're just like animals? Because no one cares, they brazenly expose their vileness, their lust."

"Humans always think themselves noble, but in truth are the lowest of all."

After Chen Mian finished speaking, she downed the rest of her drink in one gulp. The transparent glass landed on the dark marble.

When Liang Shi looked again at the pair of women kissing in the distance, they had already linked arms and left.

They had probably tested each other's kissing skills and were now contentedly going to get a room at the hotel next door.

Here, there was quick sex, vulgar conversations, overlapping desires, decadent crowds.

People seemed to have no humanity, all returning to their true nature, returning to bodily desires.

Or rather, coming here in itself was about breaking free from morality and restraint.

Footnotes:

¹ **Henpecked (妻管嚴):** A Chinese term literally meaning "strictly controlled by one's wife." It describes a husband who is completely obedient to his wife, similar to the English term "whipped" or "henpecked." Despite the seemingly negative connotation, in modern usage it's often used lightheartedly.